

Career Exploration Factsheet

What a person is interested in is strongly influenced by what a person has experienced in life. The reality for many people with disabilities is that their life experiences have been very limited, so part of a good planning process involves providing real opportunities to enable the individual to make a more informed choice concerning his/her preferences. The information gathered not only identifies specific interests and skills, but also looks at the personal characteristics and other attributes the job seeker has to offer, and what work environments and work culture will be the best and most supportive fit.

Have you ever had a certain impression about what a certain field of work or job was like, only to have that impression change significantly once you worked in that field or explored it more closely? People with disabilities are like anyone else, in that they may verbally express an interest in a field, but have a limited understanding about what that particular line of work entails. Additionally, they may have a finite view of the types of employment that are available. The following methods can be useful in determining what types of positions should be explored as part of the actual job development process.

- Informational Interviewing: Informational interviewing involves meeting with an employer, not for a job interview, but simply to gather information about the business. It is a wonderful technique for career exploration, but also for helping job seekers (and job developers) to gain experience in interacting with employers, without the pressure of an interview or appointment which is focused on a hiring decision.
- Job Tours: Similar to informational interviewing, touring various businesses can be useful in exposing the job seeker and job developer to a variety of businesses as part of a career exploration process.
- Job Shadowing: Job shadowing involves spending time actually observing an individual performing a job. This can be for a short period of time, for their entire work day, or a series of days, depending on the nature of the job, and level of interest of the job seeker.
- Community Exploration: Particularly for individuals who have trouble verbally expressing their preferences, spending time in the community with the job developer, going into various businesses, and just observing, can sometimes help in determining where a job seeker's interests and preferences lie.
- Community and Business Research: As part of the job development planning process, it can be helpful to do some research on the local business community and economy, to get a handle on what types of jobs are available (and not available), areas of growth, and who the biggest employers are. Such information is available from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (www.bls.gov/roicon.htm) as well as your state, county and local economic development offices. In addition, research on specific employers can also be helpful in planning job development, and for identifying business contacts. Sources for such information include: annual reports, business publications, newspapers, and also directly contacting the employer for an information packet. The advent of the world wide web has made collecting such information much easier, and it's recommended that the web be used as a starting point in doing research.

- One-Stop Centers: One-Stop Centers are publicly funded facilities to assist all job seekers to find employment. One-Stops have a variety of materials and services to assist in exploring possible jobs and careers, available at no charge. A nationwide listing of One-Stop Centers is available from the U.S. Department of Labor, Employment and Training Administration web site at: www.ttrc.doleta.gov/ETA. You can also contact your state or county department of labor or employment. When searching for locations of One-Stops, keep in mind that the centers often do not have One-Stop as part of their name (e.g., centers in New Hampshire are called *New Hampshire Works*, and in Massachusetts the centers go by a variety of names).
- Volunteer Work: For some individuals, and for certain areas of employment, doing volunteer work may be a helpful step as part of the career planning process. For example, many people are first attracted to the human service field as a result of volunteer work. Similarly, many people enter radio and television production work through volunteer work and internships. From a values standpoint though, it is important to recognize that volunteer work is not a substitute for paid employment. Also, from both from a legal and ethical standpoint, people with disabilities should only do volunteer work that is similar to what other members of the community are doing as volunteers. Additionally, it can sometimes take enormous effort to find a volunteer job for a person with a significant disability, when such effort would be better spent on finding paid employment. Volunteer work is an option for some people in specific situations, but not for everyone.
- Taking a Class: Taking classes in an adult education program or at a community college can be a way of finding out a job seeker's interest and aptitude in a field.
- Situational Assessment: Situational assessment is trying out a job in the community, for a few hours up to a few days, so the job seeker can determine if they are well-suited for that type of work.

The methods used for career exploration are going to vary, depending on the needs and abilities of the individual, and there is no one right formula for every individual. The following considerations should be kept in mind:

- Choose methods which are appropriate to the individual. For example, someone with limited interpersonal communication skills and abilities, is probably not going to benefit from an informational interview, and would possibly be better off doing a situational assessment.
- Use methods that are going to provide the greatest amount of information in the quickest fashion, in order to move ahead with the actual job search. Methods such as taking a class or doing volunteer work can take an extensive amount of time, and should only be used if there is a clear rationale why the job seeker is using them, or if the individual is already working and they are part of a career progression strategy.
- Keep in mind that the purpose here is to gather enough information to move ahead with the job search, not spend a lifetime researching and exploring various jobs and careers. Don't let excessive career exploration become an excuse for not moving ahead on job development.

No matter what methods are used as part of the career exploration process, it's important to gather certain information as part of this process. Two categories of information should be gathered: 1) types of work and skill requirements of jobs that the job seeker is interested in; 2)

the types of work cultures and work environments that an individual is comfortable in, and would like to work in. Job development for people with disabilities tends too often to focus exclusively on what task skills the individual has. Yet many people (with and without disabilities) succeed or fail on a job, based on how well they fit into the social environment of the workplace. In developing successful employment opportunities, the job developer and job seeker need to consider which work environments an individual's personality would be considered a real asset (e.g.-a friendly, outgoing personality is an important attribute for a customer service job, while a quiet personality might be good for someone doing data entry).

As the career exploration process progresses, the job developer and job seeker should be looking for common themes among areas of interest. For example, an individual may have explored several different fields, and while the person may have had interest in a variety of jobs, the ones where he/she is most intrigued, may be jobs where there is a great deal of interaction with others, where there is a low level of supervision, which have an informal work atmosphere, which have a variety of tasks, or which focus on a specific area.

The following is a list of some areas for consideration while undertaking a job or career exploration process. This information should be examined from two perspectives: 1) the criteria or requirements of the field or specific job in each of these areas; 2) the comfort level or ability of the job seeker to meet these requirements.

- Formality or informality of workplace
- Amount of supervision
- Level of interaction with co-workers and supervisors
- Camaraderie and socialization of employees
- Level of worker autonomy
- Variety of tasks
- Training required
- Stamina and endurance
- Mobility requirements
- Communication
- Production rate
- Strength: lifting and carrying
- Manual dexterity
- Reading requirements
- Mathematics/counting
- Level of independence required
- Customer contact
- Dress requirements
- Need to work independently
- Flexibility and changes in routine
- Complexity of tasks
- Repetitive nature of tasks
- Amount of self-initiative required
- Need/ability to tell time and time awareness
- Stress and pressure of position
- Need to ask for assistance
- Area orientation requirements
- Environment: noise, temperature, indoors/outdoors